STATE SCAN

UP: SP'S BRAHMIN RITUALS *PG 18*

MAHARASHTRA: NEVER-ENDING PAWAR SAGA *PG 19*

PTI



IRATE STATE
Protestors marching towards the Jharkhand Legislative Assembly, Ranchi, Aug. 10

JHARKHAND

GEN Z IRE SINGES SOREN

A mini-version of Jantar Mantar plays out in Ranchi, forcing the Jharkhand CM into a retreat. But he faces a sprawling wreckage

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

IT WAS A SERIES OF STEPS THAT HEMANT SOREN CLIMBED DOWN, if reluctantly. On August 19, the 26th day of student protests, he descended the final one—cancelling 22 staff selection exams, including a contentious one held in 2024. Big wickets had already fallen on August 9-10. But the agitators saw it all as band-aid for a body broken in many places. The Jharkhand recruitment system was so pock-marked by irregularities in their eyes that they would take nothing short of a total disassembly and remake. The chief minister finally acceded to a review of all competitive exams conducted since 2014. The curtains tumbled down on the main act as student leader Devendra Nath Mahto broke his fast.

The drama had peaked on August 10, Soren's 51st birthday, when the students created a visual tableau of protest that echoed Jantar Mantar, with a gherao of the assembly in the face of teargas, water cannons and lathis. That evening, former chief secretary L. Khiangte was arrested—a fortnight after he stepped down as chairman of the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC). On August 9, the high-stakes exam that sparked it all—this year's civil services prelims—